A type of social formation

The projection in political terms of the economic conditions presented above (development of monopolies and finance capital, and the rise of the organic composition of capital) so that they progress into engendering sub-imperialism requires other elements, such as a strong state, and a bourgeoisie with its own ambitions that converts these projects of political and economic expansion into national ones – which implies persuading or controlling other bourgeois fractions or persuading and subordinating other social classes domestically as well as internationally. As Marini argues:

> Sub-imperialism implies two basic components: on the one hand, an intermediate organic composition of national productive systems on the world scale and, on the other hand, the exercise of a relatively autonomous expansionist policy not only accompanied by a greater integration in the imperialist productive system but also maintained within the hegemonic framework exercised by imperialism on the international scene. Put in these terms, it seems to us that, independently of the efforts of Argentina and other countries to reach the sub-imperialist rank, in Latin America only Brazil fully manifests a phenomenon of this kind (Marini 1977a:31).

What does the exercise of a relatively autonomous expansionist policy within the framework of the global imperialist productive system and hegemony imply? Why is it that, in Latin America, Brazil – and not Mexico or Argentina – achieves this position? This obeys the dialectical principle that governs reality. Not all the new economic sub-centres that achieve an intermediate organic composition and also attain the status of exporter of manufactured goods and, to a lesser extent, of capital are in a condition to impose a sub-regional division of labour in the interest of their domestic bourgeoisie. In other words, in the whole of Latin American capitalism, only Brazil became a sub-imperialist social formation.

This is where the concrete conditions of socio-economic formations and the role of national states are important for sub-imperialism. Studied at the analytic level of socio-economic formations, the trajectory of different state formations reveals that in some societies the national state matures into a sub-imperialist formation.

From the viewpoint of the conditions necessary for dependent industrialisation to bring sub-imperialism into being, it is possible to identify five determining elements that make sub-imperialism's relatively autonomous expansionist policy possible through state action. The first is a dependent country's accession